



| STREAMING |

JioCinema: Everything, Everywhere, All at Once

With HBO in its corner and a premium plan, JioCinema is ready to take the fight to global OTT giants

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► **DID YOU HEAR?** HBO content just moved from Disney+ Hotstar to JioCinema. But you'll have to shell out ₹999 to access JioCinema Premium—annually, of course. What this means is that Jio—that saw millions of users flocking to its platform after it started free live streaming of sports tournaments like FIFA World Cup Qatar 2022 and Indian Premier League 2023—wants its finger in every pie; it is offering free content through advertising-based video-on-demand (AVOD) for its live streaming content, as well as attract-

ing new viewers for its premium content. It recently announced a slate of 100 original series and movie titles, and a paid subscription for premium content that has HBO shows like *Succession*, *The Last of Us*, etc.

Experts say this is a smart move as on the one hand, pure-play AVOD isn't sustainable for OTT players. On the other, there are premium subscribers who want an ad-free experience and are willing to pay for it. Now, as the platform goes paid, it offers viewers the ability to watch on up to four devices simultaneously, a

library of Hollywood movies and TV shows, including high-quality video and audio, all ad-free. While the free streaming of sports tournaments brought audiences to the platform, the premium plan will help build loyalty. "The free live streaming of IPL has ensured that JioCinema consumption grew substantially in April 2023, while its average daily engagement reached 50 minutes," says Mihir Shah, VP at Media Partners Asia (MPA), a market research firm. "But sustained viewership levels will remain critical in the absence of IPL... especially as it has increased investments in local and premium international content."

Consumers watching global content definitely don't want to watch ads, and hence most premium streaming platforms have an ad-free offering that JioCinema is now targeting. Meanwhile IPL, currently being offered for free, has helped Jio gain traction among viewers who may find it difficult to pay for a subscription, and who are used to free services like YouTube. But an ad-free SVOD model with HBO content and Jio's own original content will help them target